

Korean Honorification as Animacy-Based Gender

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1. Introduction

A component of a successful syntactic theory is an exhaustive but parsimonious feature inventory over which syntactic operations like Agree may apply. There is a tension between empirical adequacy and parsimony: unique paradigms might seem to warrant dedicated features which do nothing but derive those phenomena. Such a case is honorification (the grammatical marking of politeness) in Korean (1).

- (1) kamdok{-**kkeyse**/-i} wuli-eykey selywu-lul ponay-**si**-ess-ta.
 director-**NOM.HON**/-NOM US-DAT document-ACC send-**HON**s-PST-DECL
 ‘The director sent us the document.’ (‘director’ is to be respected) (Jou 2024:3)

The sentence in (1) displays subject honorification, which indicates respect towards the grammatical subject (*kamdok* ‘director’; see Jou 2024). Subject honorification involves an obligatory verbal reflex *-(u)si-*, and an optional nominative case allomorph *-kkeyse* (cf. the non-honorific nominative *-il-ka*).

These morphemes are unique to honorification in Korean. This has led a variety of theoretical accounts to propose a feature that is also unique to honorification — for example, [HON] — to govern their realization (Koopman 2005, Choi 2010, Ackema & Neeleman 2018, Choi & Harley 2019, Portner et al. 2019, Jou 2024). Others argue this is an undue complication, and that honorification can be captured without bespoke features like [HON] (Kim & Sells 2007, Song et al. 2019, Kim & Findlay 2023, Wang 2023). Instead, it’s claimed that, cross-linguistically, honorification repurposes other categories (e.g., number, person) and recruits existing morphosyntactic paradigms ((2), Wang 2023).

- (2) *Attested honorification systems* (Wang 2023:1288)

Category	Honorific	Non-honorific	Example Language
Number	PL	SG	French
Person	3	(1,) 2	Spanish
Definiteness	Indefinite	Definite	Ainu

Despite it being common for honorific systems to utilize existing paradigms and features, several languages resist this characterization, and express honorification via dedicated morphology (Nengone, Muna, Maithili, Magahi; Wang 2023:1339–1340). As discussed, Korean is another such language: the morphemes *-kkeyse* and *-(u)si-* are unique to honorification, and there is little φ -agreement to repurpose, in any case (Yoon 2018:14).¹ Such languages appear problematic for the view that honorification is reducible to other (φ -)paradigms. I, however, show that although Korean honorification involves dedicated morphology, it does not require a unique feature class. Rather, I propose that what has been called [HON] is an interpretable animacy-based gender feature housed on *n*, enriching both syntactic (e.g., Jou 2024) and semantico-pragmatic (e.g., Wang 2023) feature-based accounts of honorification.

I argue for this by first diagnosing the position of the feature which controls subject honorification in Korean. I do so using the following puzzle: in possessive constructions where the possessor is a respected individual, in certain dialects of Korean, inalienably possessed subjects can exceptionally trigger honorification agreement (3a), while alienably possessed subjects cannot (3b).

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¹ Korean arguably has optional plural subject-verb agreement (Choe 1988, Lee 1991, Kim 1994, Koopman 2005).

- (3) a. [halmeni-kkeyse/-uy **phal**]-i aphu-si-ta. *inalienable possession*
 grandmother-NOM.HON/-GEN **arm**-NOM hurt-HONS-DECL
 ‘Grandmother’s arm hurts.’
- b. % [halmeni-kkeyse/-uy **chascan**]-i alumtaw-usi-ta. *alienable possession*
 grandmother-NOM.HON/-GEN **cup**-NOM be.lovely-HONS-DECL
 Int.: ‘Grandmother’s cup is lovely.’ (adapted from Kim & Findlay 2023:6)

In (3a) and (3b), an inanimate noun, possessed by a respected individual (*halmeni* ‘grandmother’), is the grammatical subject. For some speakers, only the inalienably possessed *phal* ‘arm’ can exceptionally control the honorific agreement morpheme *-(u)si-*; the alienably possessed *chascan* ‘cup’ cannot. From this point on, I only discuss the dialects that observe the contrast in (3) (but see Kim & Findlay 2023).

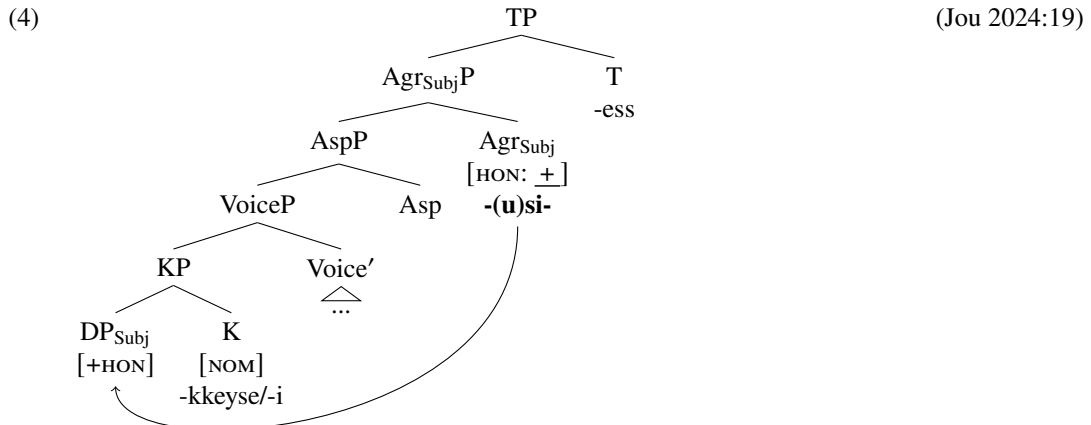
The pattern in (3) receives a syntactic explanation assuming that φ -features are distributed into distinct positions (Piccolo 1991, Ritter 1991), with gender on *n* (Kramer 2015), and that inalienable possessors are internal to *nP*, while alienable possessors are not (Myler 2016, 2018). This closely associates the positions of gender (*n*) and inalienable possessors (Spec, *nP*). Via mechanisms of “inherited gender” (Adamson 2024; see Evans 1994, Olsson 2021), features on *n* are expected to be sensitive to possession type. If [HON] is (a gender feature) on *n*, it would show the same sensitivity, leading to contrasts as in (3).

This paper proceeds as follows. Section 2 provides an overview of some Korean honorification data, as well as the syntactic mechanism I assume for subject honorification. Section 3 then diagnoses the position of [HON] as on *n* and then applies Adamson’s (2024) “inherited gender” machinery to the Korean data. In section 4, I suggest [HON] is an interpretable animacy-based gender feature, with the aim of advancing our understanding of how animacy relates to other φ -categories. Section 5 concludes.

2. Korean honorification: background and assumptions

2.1. Subject honorification and honorific case markers

I focus on subject honorification, marked by the morpheme *-(u)si-* (1), and set aside other Korean honorifics, including addressee honorification (e.g., Jou 2024), speech style particles (e.g., Portner et al. 2019), and the honorific suffix *-nim*. I assume Jou’s (2024) Agree account for subject honorification (4).



The morpheme *-(u)si-* expones a head in the verbal spine (above Asp but below T) which enters into an Agree relation with the subject, with respect to [+HON]. For the sake of exposition, I represent the feature which controls honorification as the simple bivalent placeholder [$\pm$ HON], but I revise this repeatedly.

With the analysis of the obligatory reflex of subject honorification *-(u)si-* set, I now turn to discuss the optional honorific nominative case allomorph *-kkeyse*. The allomorph *-kkeyse* is optional because using *-(u)si-* without *-kkeyse* results in an acceptable honorific sentence (Jou 2024:9 and references cited there). Omitting both *-(u)si-* and *-kkeyse* does not result in ungrammaticality but, rather, a non-honorific sentence, which is situationally inappropriate if respect is called for (Jou 2024:3). Using the optional honorific nominative case marker *-kkeyse* without *-(u)si-* results in degraded acceptability, however (5).

- (5) kamdok-**{i/?kkeyse}** wus-ess-ta.
director-NOM/NOM.HON laugh-PST-DECL
'The director laughed.'

The contrast in (5) shows that the honorific case marker *-kkeyse* depends on the presence of the more reliable reflex of subject honorification *-(u)si-*. Assuming that *-(u)si-* is necessarily realized if and only if the subject bears [+HON], (5) can be taken to show that *-kkeyse*, too, may only appear in the context of [+HON], it just does not do so obligatorily. For the sake of concreteness, I again present a portion of Jou’s (2024:18) account, here for the exponence of the honorific case marker *-kkeyse*, but note that optionality must be incorporated in some way that I leave underspecified into Vocabulary Insertion rule (6a).

In Korean, Case allomorphy for honorific status is also attested for dative case (7).

- (9) % *khephi*-ka nao-**si**-ess-supni-ta.
 coffee-NOM come.out-**HONS**-PST-HON_{Addr}-DECL
 ‘The coffee (that you (respected) ordered) is ready.’ (uttered by barista) (Yoon 2018:15)

In (9), *khephi* ‘coffee’ is associated with someone who warrants respect (the customer, from the barista’s perspective), but speakers who reject (8b) or (9) report such examples as “overdone” with respect to honorification, to the point of sarcasm or rudeness; these sentences require that the inanimate subject not only be anthropomorphized, but also demand respect itself (Hanyoung Byun, p.c.). That is, conservative subject honorification requires that the respected individual be human (see section 4). Because of this, I do not discuss potential inalienable possession categories where the possessor must be inanimate.

The following examples, however, verify that the other categories of common inalienably possessed nouns exceptionally control honorification. Example (8a) above shows that body parts allow this, but (10) does the same for clothing, (11) for kinship terms, and (12) for a mental state (in this case, an affliction).

- (10) [apeci-uy **somay**]-ka ccalp-usey-yo.
 father-GEN **sleeve**-NOM short-**HONS**-DECL.POL
 ‘The sleeves (of your shirt) are short, Dad.’ (Lit. ‘Dad’s sleeves...’) (Sohn 2001)
- (11) [sensayngnim-uy twuljjay **ttanim**]-i cham kowu-**si**-ney-yo.
 teacher-GEN second **daughter**-NOM really beautiful-**HONS**-DECL.POL
 ‘Teacher, your second daughter is really beautiful.’ (Lit. ‘Teacher’s daughter...’) (Choi 2010:70)
- (12) [samonim-uy **kothong**]-i khu-**si**-keyss-e-yo.
 madam-GEN **pain**-NOM big-**HONS**-FUT-DECL.POL
 ‘The pain that the Mrs. suffers must be great.’ (Lit. ‘Madam’s pain...’) (Choi 2010:66)

In all of the above cases, respect is being shown towards the possessor of the grammatical subject (i.e., *apeci* ‘father’, *sensayngnim* ‘teacher’, *samonim* ‘madam’), and not towards either the inanimate grammatical subject nor, in the case of (11), towards the animate possessum *ttanim* ‘daughter’.

Other relations which may seem to involve a close link between the possessor and possessum do not allow for exceptional subject honorification. For example, author or creator relations do not apparently pattern as inalienable possession in Korean. In (13), despite being written by a respected individual (*kyosunim* ‘professor’), the inanimate subject *nonmwun* ‘thesis’ cannot trigger subject honorification.

- (13) [kyosunim-i-uy **nonmwun**]-i { % ki-**si**-ta / kil-ta }.
 professor-NOM/GEN **thesis**-NOM long-**HONS**-DECL / long-DECL
 ‘The professor’s thesis is long.’

So, there is a class of nouns which can be inalienably possessed and which can exceptionally control honorification agreement. Inalienable possession has been interpreted as being due to a specific flavor of *n* — for example, an *n* of inalienable possession may demand an additional argument (the possessor; Myler 2016:79, Adamson 2024). To say that the class of inalienably possessed nouns is the one which allows exceptional honorification, then, is to say that there is a kind of *n* which allows for this phenomenon.

3. [HON] is on *n*

I now leverage the observation of the previous section — that it is inalienably possessed nouns which allow exceptional subject honorification in conservative dialects of Korean, and that inalienable possession is a phenomenon borne out by flavors of *n* — to argue that the feature that controls honorification, often called [HON], is located on *n*. To do so, I extend Adamson’s (2024) account for very similar “inherited gender” phenomena. By diagnosing the location of [HON] as on *n*, I make the claim that [HON] may be a kind of gender feature, since gender is known to be housed on *n* (Kramer 2015).

3.1. Inherited gender and inalienable possession: Adamson’s (2024) account

Inherited gender is a phenomenon in which the grammatical gender of a possessed noun is determined by the gender of its inalienable but not alienable possessors (Evans 1994, Olsson 2017, Adamson 2024).

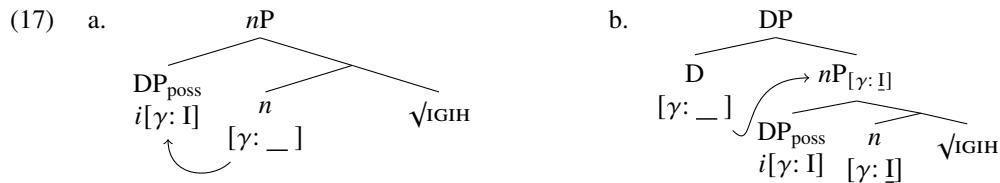
In Coastal Marind, for example, certain nouns are always inalienably possessed, and their gender is determined by the gender of the possessor. Nouns like *igih* ‘name’ (14) and *nanVh* ‘face’ (15) participate in this phenomenon, where gender I encompasses human men and gender II human women and all animals (Olsson 2021).⁴ In (14), grammatical gender is reflected in the form of a following demonstrative (*epelupe* ‘that’), and in (15), in the form of the postposition *hV* ‘like’ and the noun *nanVh* ‘name’ itself.

- (14) Coastal Marind (Bruno Olsson’s fieldwork *apud* Adamson 2024:249)
- | | |
|--|--|
| a. igih e-pe waninggap k-a.
name I-DIST good PRS.NEUT-3.A
‘That [male] name is good.’ | b. igih u-pe waninggap k-a.
name II-DIST good PRS.NEUT-3.A
‘That [female/animal] name is good.’ |
|--|--|
- (15) Coastal Marind (Olsson 2017:106)
- | | |
|---|---|
| a. basik hi nanih
pig(II) like.I face.I
‘[man’s] face like a pig’ | b. basik hu nanuh
pig(II) like.II face.II
‘[woman’s] face like a pig’ |
|---|---|

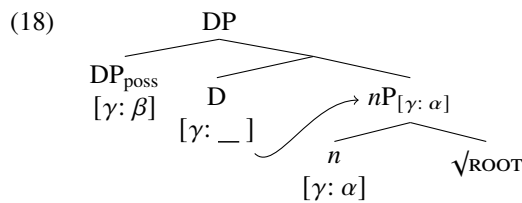
Adamson (2024:250–251) proposes that in certain languages, the flavor of *n* associated with inalienable possession is unspecified for a gender value, despite requiring one. Simplifying to just genders I and II, one could propose the following flavors of *n* for Coastal Marind, where human male roots are licensed by (16a), human female and animal roots by (16b), and inalienably possessed roots by (16c).

- (16) a. *n* [γ : I] ($\sqrt{\text{PATUL}}$ ‘boy’) b. *n* [γ : II] ($\sqrt{\text{KYASOM}}$ ‘girl’) c. *n* [γ : _] ($\sqrt{\text{IGIH}}$ ‘name’)

In order to receive a value for gender, the *n* in (16c) must probe and enter into an Agree relation. A gender probe on *n* will be able to enter into such an Agree relation with its specifier under Cyclic Agree (Béjar & Rezac 2009), and I assume inalienable possessors occupy Spec, *n*P (Myler 2016, Myler 2018). So, the gender of *n*(P)s like (16c) will be determined by that of their inalienable possessor. This is schematized in (17a); (17b) shows one mechanism by which the entire DP can be subsequently valued for gender.



In (17b), I show D-*n* agreement (Danon 2001, Pesetsky & Torrego 2008) as the mechanism by which features are passed from *n*(P) to D(P), while Adamson (2024) assumes feature percolation (Norris 2014). Regardless of this choice, the crucial outcome is that the DP in (17b) bears the gender of the inalienable possessor. Assuming that alienable possessors are in Spec, DP, (18) shows that DPs involving alienable possession always surface with the predetermined gender of the possessum, and not that of the possessor.⁵



A φ -probe in the nominal spine in a position higher than *n* is not expected to be sensitive to possessor type, as (18) demonstrates: such a probe seemingly will always copy the valuation of *n*(P), either via feature percolation or some other mechanism (see fn.5). Only the privileged relation between a probe on *n* and an inalienable possessor in Spec, *n*P allows for an analysis of phenomena in which only inalienable, and not alienable, possessors determine the featural valuation of the DPs they are contained within.

⁴ There are more gender categories in Coastal Marind. See Olsson (2021) for detailed documentation and discussion.

⁵ If alienable possessors occupy a position lower than D (e.g., Spec, PossP, Myler 2016, Myler 2018), something must ensure that D still only Agrees with the features on *n*(P), since the alienable possessor would presumably be a closer goal than *n*(P). This could mean either relativizing the probe on D (such that it ignores DPs), enforcing strict head-to-head agreement in the nominal spine, or using a mechanism like feature percolation (Norris 2014), instead.

3.2. Conservative Korean subject honorification involves inherited gender

The conservative Korean subject honorification data are another “inheritance” phenomenon: the honorific status of inalienable, but not alienable, possessors is inherited by the possessum. In this subsection, then, I make the straightforward proposal that [HON] is located on *n*, allowing Adamson’s (2024) proposal to be extended directly to the Korean data at hand.

First, recall that honorification morphology can be removed while preserving grammaticality (19).

- (19) a. kamdok-i ... ponay-ess-ta.
director-NOM send-PST-DECL
‘the director (**non-honorific**)...’
b. kamdok-kkeyse ... ponay-si-ess-ta.
director-NOM.HON send-HONs-PST-DECL
‘the director (**honorific**)...’

That is, any human Korean root can be respected ([+HON]) or not ([−HON]). In terms of *ns*, I propose there are *ns* valued [±HON] which are each compatible with human-denoting roots, but neither of which necessarily select for any root; I return to the exact semantic contribution of “[+HON]” in section 4, where I also revise the identity of [±HON]. To round out the temporarily simplified inventory of Korean *n*, I propose a *n* of inalienable possession in Korean that is unvalued for [HON], and which probes for a value.

- (20) a. *n* [HON: +] b. *n* [HON: −] c. *n*_{inalienable poss.} [HON: −]

With these different flavors of *n* in hand, I directly analogize the presented account of inherited gender to exceptional Korean subject honorification. The key Korean constructions observed so far are a kind of inherited gender phenomenon, where [(+)HON] is the “gender” being inherited — I will expand on this, too, in the next section. The schemata presented below demonstrate how inalienable possession DPs will surface the [±HON] value of their possessor (21a), while alienable possession DPs will surface the [±HON] value of their possessum (21b); they are essentially identical to (17) and (18).

- (21) a. DP: [HON: +]
D [HON: −] ② → nP[HON: +]
 DP_{poss} [HON: +] *n* [HON: −] √_{PHAL} ‘arm’
 halmeni-uy
 ①
- b. DP: [HON: −]
DP_{poss} [HON: +] D [HON: −] nP[HON: −]
halmeni-uy [HON: −] *n* [HON: −] √_{CHASCAN} ‘cup’

Applying Adamson’s (2024) proposal to the exceptional honorification data is only so straightforward given the novel claim that the honorification feature [HON] is on *n*. If, for example, [HON] and an associated probe were located on a slightly higher head (anywhere between the position of inalienable and alienable possessors), it would be considerably less apparent how one could syntactically account for the interplay between inalienable possession and honorification. Such an account divorces [HON] from *n*, and therefore from inalienable possession, too. It would have to be stipulated that the slightly higher [HON] probe appears only in inalienable possession constructions, and that otherwise the value of [±HON] is set without Agree. Under the current proposal, however, the [HON] probe simply is the *n* of inalienable possession.

In the next section, I further develop the claim that [HON] is a gender feature by comparing animacy-based alternations in Korean to animacy-based grammatical gender systems found in other languages. I ultimately propose that [HON] be incorporated as a part of such an animacy-based gender system in Korean, and point out that such an approach achieves in reducing honorification to an existing (φ-)category. Unlike an approach in which [HON] remains a somewhat mysterious feature in some unspecified position low in the nominal spine, the current proposal concretely places it as a gender feature on *n*.

4. [HON] is animacy-based gender

Despite having identified [HON] as being located on *n*, it has not yet determined what it means to say that [HON] is a gender feature there. This section suggests one potential identity: [HON] is animacy-based gender. I first demonstrate that animacy is a grammatically active category in Korean, then compare

animacy in Korean to animacy-based gender systems found cross-linguistically, and, finally, motivate the incorporation of an honorific feature like [HON] into an independent hierarchy of animacy values.

4.1. Animacy alternations in Korean and elsewhere

Recall from (7) that there is at least one alternation in the dative case marker in Korean: respected individuals are marked with *-kkey* and non-respected individuals with *-eykey*. However, an additional dative marker, *-ey*, which was left out of that paradigm, marks inanimate arguments in opposition to animate or respected human arguments. The more complete paradigm is demonstrated in (22).

- (22) Cheli-ka { changmwun-ey / chinkwu-**eykey** / halmeni-**kkey** } ppoppo-hay-ss-ta.
 Cheli-NOM window-DAT.IN / friend-DAT.AN / grandmother-DAT.HON kiss-do-PST-DECL
 ‘Cheli kissed the window/(his) friend/(his) grandmother.’

Korean dative case morphologically distinguishes three categories: inanimates, animates, and respected humans. A simple bivalent feature $[\pm\text{HON}]$ is insufficient to capture this. I instead propose a hierarchy of asymmetrically entailing privative animacy features in Korean, from a default categorial feature $[\gamma]$ (which by Gricean reasoning can be interpreted as inanimate on this scale) to animate to $[\text{HON}]$ (23).

- (23) $\text{HON} \subset \text{ANIMATE} \subset \gamma$

I include $[\text{HON}]$ in this asymmetrically entailing hierarchy not only because respected individuals participate in the same dative case paradigm as inanimate and animate arguments, but also because only animates can semantically or non-exceptionally control subject honorification (Choi 2010:72, see also section 2). That is, an argument bearing $[\text{HON}]$ entails that that argument is animate. The next subsection will further expand on what it means to place $[\text{HON}]$ in an asymmetric entailment relation with an animacy feature, as well as point out cross-linguistic parallels and precedents. In any case, though, this hierarchy of features in (23) allows for the following Vocabulary Insertion rules for Korean dative case, where *-ey* is an elsewhere exponent in opposition to the more narrowly defined animate and honorific allomorphs.

- (24) a. *-kkey* $\leftrightarrow [\text{DAT}] / [\text{HON}] __$ b. *-eykey* $\leftrightarrow [\text{DAT}] / [\text{ANIM}] __$ c. *-ey* $\leftrightarrow [\text{DAT}]$

In the previous section, it was argued that $[\text{HON}]$ is located on *n*, the known locus of grammatical gender (Kramer 2015). It seems straightforward to assume that $[\text{HON}]$ is a type of gender feature, then. I propose that the hierarchy listed in (23) is therefore one of animacy-based gender features. This allows for the following inventory of Korean *n* in (25), including the valueless *n* of inalienable possession (25d).

- (25) a. *n* $[\gamma: \text{HON}]$ b. *n* $[\gamma: \text{ANIM}]$ c. *n* (default) / *n* $[\gamma]$ d. *n*_{iposs} $[\gamma: __]$

Each of these *n* license different roots. The *n* in (25d) licenses those that are inalienably possessed, like body parts, kinship terms, and the other categories surveyed in section 2. The default *n* in (25c) licenses inanimate roots, while (25a) and (25b) both can license animate roots.

From a cross-linguistic standpoint, claiming that grammatical gender can be based in semantic animacy is far from a new claim. After social gender (e.g., masculine-feminine-neuter systems), animacy is the most common semantic underpinning of noun class or grammatical gender (Corbett 2012). In Bantu languages, for instance, noun class was historically conditioned by animacy (Denny & Creider 1986), where noun class is argued to be a more complex system of grammatical gender (Carstens 1991, 2024). Algonquian languages are also well-known for having grammatical gender systems based in animacy: all humans and animates belong to one category, but inanimate nouns are assigned arbitrarily (26).

- (26) Cree (Algonquian)
 a. nikamon-**a**
 song-PL.INAN
 ‘songs’
 b. askihk-**ak**
 kettle-PL.AN
 ‘kettles’ (Goddard 2002:199)

The semantically inanimate Cree noun *askihk* ‘kettle’ is arbitrarily grammatically animate (26b).

With respect to Korean having a grammatical gender system based in animacy, a complication is that I am not aware of any arbitrarily assigned roots (e.g., a semantically inanimate root which exceptionally

triggers animate morphology). In addition, as observed, human-denoting roots can be either respected, or not. This makes it seem as though it is possible for all human-denoting roots to be licensed by either (25a) or (25b); it is unclear that there are any roots which are necessarily and arbitrarily licensed by only one or the other. This arbitrary behavior, however, is crucial in order to fully bolster the claim that [HON] is a grammatical gender feature, as this arbitrariness is how grammatical gender is expected to function. This is a rather large caveat, and suggests that more work must be done to fully demystify the identity of the feature which controls subject honorification. As a way to push the current analysis forward, though, I continue to propose that [HON] is an animacy-based gender feature housed on *n*, and now turn to show how an honorific feature can be incorporated into a system of animacy.

4.2. Honorification as a superhuman animacy value

Cross-linguistically, “animacy” is a grammatical category which often distinguishes between more than just the two categories of inanimate and animate. Developing the work of Smith-Stark (1974), Corbett (2000:56) proposes the following hierarchy of animacy values active in human language (27).

- (27) speaker > addressee > 3rd person > kin > **(rational)** > human > animate > inanimate

Included in this hierarchy are person features, a point which I return to shortly. Crucial to the current discussion, however, is the inclusion of non-person animacy categories above animate and human. Tamil is cited as a language which grammatically distinguishes “rational” humans from irrational ones (e.g., infants). That is, there are animacy systems which divide the category “human” into higher and lower divisions. This is not uncommon if one considers honorification a sort of this subdivision: for example, Southeastern Sierra Zapotec languages show a four-way animacy-based alternation which grammatically distinguishes inanimates, non-human animates (animals), humans, and respected humans or elders (28).

- (28) *Santiago Laxopa Zapotec pronouns* (Toosarvandani 2017:129)

	Strong	Clitic
3.ELDER	le’	=e’ (subject) ~ =ne’ (object)
3.HUMAN	leba’	=ba’
3.ANIMAL	leb	=(e)b
3.INANIMATE	lenh	=(e)nh

The table in (28) demonstrates this kind of animacy paradigm for Santiago Laxopa Zapotec third-person pronouns. Just like Korean dative case, this is a single morphological paradigm which is partially conditioned by animacy but which also sports a category sensitive to respect and honorification: that of the “elder” category. For Zapotec, PCC-like effects involving cliticization motivate the following animacy feature hierarchy (29), defined in (30) (Foley & Toosarvandani 2022, Sichel & Toosarvandani 2024).

- (29) ELDER $\subset$ HUMAN $\subset$ ANIMATE $\subset \pi$

- (30) a. $\llbracket \text{ELDER} \rrbracket^c = \lambda x . x \text{ hold(s) a salient social role in } c$
b. $\llbracket \text{HUMAN} \rrbracket = \lambda x . x \text{ is/are human}$
c. $\llbracket \text{ANIMATE} \rrbracket = \lambda x . x \text{ is/are animate}$
d. $\llbracket \pi \rrbracket = \lambda x . x \text{ is a potential discourse subject or object}$ (Toosarvandani 2023:782–6)

I adopt a portion of this hierarchy for Korean, and propose that the feature which controls subject honorification is the independently motivated ELDER. The choice of name is obviously inconsequential; what is crucial is the novel identification of [HON] as one and the same as the high animacy feature ELDER, placing [HON] within an independently argued hierarchy of animacy features. I suggest that in Korean, ELDER has the same semantic contribution as laid out in (30a), where “salient social role in *c*” picks out those roles generally targeted by honorification, while noting that this leaves some interpretative questions open. Note, too, that it’s unclear that the feature HUMAN is necessary for the analysis of Korean; that is, I know of no paradigm which grammatically distinguishes humans from non-human animates. This might suggest that although the animacy features in (29) stand in an asymmetric entailment relation, they may not also stand in a typological markedness relation where the activity of, for example, ELDER entails the activity of HUMAN in that same language (see Béjar 2003, Harbour 2011, 2016).

One final novelty of the current proposal ought to be discussed: although for Korean, I adopt part of the feature hierarchy proposed in (29), I change the categorial identity of this hierarchy. In Zapotec, these animacy features are implicated as a part of the person paradigm (see Sichel & Toosarvandani 2024), while I repurpose them in Korean to be gender features more akin to the animacy-based grammatical gender systems of Bantu or Algonquian languages. These animacy features must not be in the same hierarchy as person features in Korean (although they may indeed be in Zapotec), for the following reason: such a system erroneously predicts that first- and second-person subjects will always trigger subject honorification in Korean. In a hierarchy where local person and animacy features are a part of the same hierarchy, first- and second-person pronouns receive the following featural decomposition (31):

- (31) a. 1: $\delta - \pi - \text{ANIMATE} - \text{HUMAN} - \text{ELDER} - \text{PARTICIPANT} - \text{SPEAKER}$
 b. 2: $\delta - \pi - \text{ANIMATE} - \text{HUMAN} - \text{ELDER} - \text{PARTICIPANT}$ (Sichel & Toosarvandani 2024:20)

Under these featural decompositions, first- and second-person pronouns bear the feature *ELDER*. Since I suggest that this feature triggers subject honorification in Korean, it is incorrectly predicted that first- and second-person subjects should obligatorily trigger subject honorification. So, these animacy features must not be entailed by local person features in Korean, and I instead propose that they are gender features.

5. Conclusion

This work advances existing accounts of honorification by specifying the identity of [HON], a label recognized to be merely a useful simplification (Jou 2024:8, fn.8). Using otherwise puzzling facts regarding the sensitivity of Korean subject honorification to inalienable versus alienable possession, I locate [HON] as being on *n*, where gender features are known to be (Kramer 2015). I analyze Korean as having an animacy-based gender system akin to those found in Bantu and Algonquian languages. Finally, I suggest reducing “[HON]” to an independently motivated φ -feature: the high animacy feature *ELDER*. In doing so, I further debates regarding animacy’s relation to other φ -categories; I propose Korean as another language, alongside Bantu and Algonquian languages, which incorporates animacy into grammatical gender, while languages like Zapotec recruit animacy as a phenomenon of person.

This approach bolsters any feature-based account of honorification in languages with bespoke honorification morphology. Rather than requiring a unique feature (class) to account for such phenomena, otherwise little-used φ -paradigms could be recruited (like animacy-based gender in Korean). This raises the obvious question of whether other languages with dedicated honorific morphology (Nengone, Muna, Maithili, Magahi; see Wang 2023:1339–1340) could be analyzed in a similar way, making use of animacy-based φ -features. An exciting avenue for future work is asking similar questions of languages which have both dedicated and φ -repurposing honorific morphology, like Amharic (Ruth Kramer, p.c.).

In investigating these lines of research, however, it is interesting to note that although the current proposal reduces [HON] to a φ -feature, like Wang (2023) suggests for the analysis of honorification cross-linguistically, Wang (2023) specifically claims that it is the least marked and least presuppositional entry in a (φ -)paradigm which is recruited for honorification (e.g., indefinite not definite, third-person not local person, etc.). I suggest Korean animacy-based honorification recruits arguably the most marked and semantically specific value, raising questions of whether these two approaches can be reconciled, or if there are two distinct classes of strategies, cross-linguistically, for honorification: one with “dedicated” morphology based in animacy, and the other repurposing non-animacy features.

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